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From the Editor in Chief's desk:

By Swami Paranand Tirth

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Aesthetics versus Metaphysics

I remember having read somewhere that Goethe while reading Kalidas was so possessed by the super fluidity of ecstatic rapture that he started dancing and jumping around. Metaphysical vindication of aesthetic bliss was established by Indian thinkers in the tenth century, when the two seemingly conflicting vistas of human creativity literature and philosophy were compelled to reconcile. As separate

faculties neither would have existed. Metaphysics would have passed into oblivion for want of agreeability or interest factor on the other hand aesthetics would have lost its import without a sound metaphysical substratum.

Aesthetics specially as poetry, dance and dramaturgy sought metaphysical justification and thus the dry hermeneutic and ascetic discipline of metaphysical pursuit gained the impetus of "the pursuit of happiness". This replaced the stoic asceticism with a philosophically justified virtual hedonism which later on evolved into the form of Tantra and Agama. The superfluous bliss I talked about in the beginning is called चमत्कार or relishing, which in turn is the very nature of the lord termed as विमर्श or आनंद.

"He is verily the रसः only after attaining

rasa a man becomes blissful ", proclaims one of the prominent Upanishads.

In Saundaryalahari of Adishankara the power and process of creation of the universal phenomena has been conceptualised as various moods and emotions (रसः) emanating from the cosmic dance of the celestial couple . Both are depicted semiotically as well as metaphysically as the inseparable conjugal of word and meaning .

*तवाधारेमूले सहसमयया लास्यपरया
तवात्मानं मन्ये नवरस माहा तांडवनटम्
उभाभ्यामेताभ्यां उदयविधिमुद्दिश्यदयया
सनाथाभ्यां जज्ञे जनकजननीमज्जगदिदम् ।

(Saundarya lahari)

Now since an aesthete's world view consists of the dynamics of word and meaning ,moods and emotion ,prakash and vimarsha or nada and bindu ,all creativity

being an echo of the primordial process of creation is essentially a metaphysical and spiritual phenomena . Abhinavagupta has postulated that the essence of poetry is rasa and the essence of rasa is Dhvani. His doctrine of Dhvani is a great edifice for creative innovations even from a futuristic stand point .He doesn't consider the phenomena of chamtkar or (relishing the aesthetic bliss) as merely comparable to the bliss of superconscious experience but he claims it to be the bliss of super consciousness per se .

Swami Paranand Tirth
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Editorial



I visualize Abhinavaguptacharya walking with his disciples towards Bhairava cave singing 'Vyapat Charachar Bhava Vishesham' and I wonder what it is like to walk into the mouth of death willingly and embrace it whole heartedly. Then I recall, Abhinava was no ordinary mortal but a Yogini-bhu, born with a strong desire to learn and disseminate knowledge. He possessed a special capacity for liberation and the personalities with this special character do not simply die. They rather awaken in a different world and leave their mark forever in this phenomenal world. For them death is but an extension of the journey of life and the ultimate aim is to attain complete unison with the divine. His views are aptly expressed in these words translated by Sanderson,

"I shall place this triple universe with the sap of its diverse experiences on the 'wine press' of my heart cakra, and bear down upon it with the weight of insight. The awareness that flows forth is the ultimate nectar that ends [fear of] death, old age, and rebirth forever. With this ultimate offering I shall gratify You constantly, pouring it into the fire of deepest radiance."

With the blessings of our guru Swami Paranandtirth ji, we have tried to bring together in this issue various facets of Abhinavagupta, as a scholar, a mystic yogi and an enlightened soul. To begin with we have an editorial by Swami Paranand Tirthji on the 'metaphysical vindication of aesthetic bliss' explaining how in Tantras both metaphysics and aesthetics come

together to create an idea of divine pleasure, the ultimate aim of an aspirant.

Next we have Swamiji's article on Madhuraja's 'Gurunathparamarsh', in which the author sings peans to his guru Abhinavagupta providing a poetic pen picture of the regal ambiance and grandeur of his guru.

'Quitessence of the highest Purpose: A translation, introduction and analysis of Sri Abhinavagupta's Paramarthasara' is the title of an erudite article by Dr. Jeffrey S. Lidke. In this essay, the author has attempted to illuminate how the Paramārthasāra, a seminal text by Abhinavagupta serves as a guide for the process of the awakening and internal ascension of kuṇḍalinī-śakti.

Next we have the first part of the exhaustive article on Camatkara aspect by Niraj Kumar. The author aptly traces the development of Camatkara theory by focusing on important aspects of Abhinavagupta's Poetics. Following this we have a general article on the aesthetic ideas proposed by Abhinavagupta focusing on rasa and rasa-dhwani concepts by Geetika Kaw Kher.

We end this issue with an illustrated report on YTA presence in various seminars and conferences held on Abhinavagupta by Rashneek Kher.

(Dr. Geetika Kaw Kher is Asst. Professor at Amity School of Fine Arts (ASFA) and teaches History of Art, Aesthetics and Art Criticism)

Abhinavgupta from his disciple's viewpoint

Swami Paranand Tirth

श्रीमान्नः पातु साक्षादभिनववपुषा दक्षिणामूर्तिदेवः ।

(May lord Shri Dakshinamurti, himself incarnated as Abhinavguptacharya be our succour by imparting the supreme wisdom .)

There is cardinal tenet regarding the guru in the eastern thought , one must never consider his preceptor as a common place mortal hence in the east a pupil felicitates his guru as Brahma , Vishnu, Maheshwar and Parbrahma . That is to say -god the creator , sustainer and destroyer and the absolute principle .

I asked one eminent monk whether a guru should be adored as Ishwara or the absolute Brahma . The Swami answered in another question , "Is Ishwara also not Brahm? ". Ishwara, as the author of Panchadashi, Shrividyaranyas puts it , is a conditioned aspect of the absolute principle as reflected in his chiti or the power of consciousness . A monistic guru owing to his unison with the absolute principle is also the universal self and thus the self of the aspirant too.

He as one arcane hymn goes

स्वात्मानं प्रकटीकरोति भजतां यो मुद्राया भद्रया

He incarnates before those who adore him with a gesture of benevolence .This gesture is a mystic mudra displayed by joining the tips of the thumb and index finger of the right hand while the rest of the three are stretched out. This is also known as chin mudra and Hetu or Tark mudra . The gesture of awareness and the gesture of reasoning . The benevolence in this parlance is objective, the guru redeems the befitting disciple . Unlike in the Shaiv Agama the aspirant is required to have all prerequisites like intelligence, brilliance , knowledge of the scriptures , enhanced cognitive and reasoning faculties and ability to make right choice .

मेधावी पुरुषोविद्वान् ऊहा पोहविचक्षणः
(vivekchudamani)

Madhuraj while mentioning 'guru' in his Guruparamarsha is aware that the process of redemption has to be one sided . So guru is the embodiment of Ishwara who is empowered with his anugraha Shakti that prevents him from remaining absorbed in his bliss of isolation or waiting for his chosen neophyte to acquire a certain degree of moral and intellectual refinement that would render him fit for redemption .

Abhinavgupta is the exponent of sixfold yoga and has ruled out the preceding two limbs dealing with ethical perfection ,ablution faith and devotion etc. These can be induced into the disciple within a trice once he is capable of receiving the spiritual energy or चिच्छक्ति -on his own it might take eons . This yoga must not be confused with the six yogas of the preceding or contemporary Buddhist mystics like Naropa or Vasubandhu.

The tradition of the propagation of spiritual experience predates dialectical and discursive lineage . Discursive tradition developed as the main stream line came to be impeded by self assertive agnostics ,skeptics and heretics . To prevent disciples from getting waylaid by arrogant dilettantes and skeptics ,rational explanations had to be sought ,that too not to win an argument or to defeat some erroneous dogmas in debate but to strengthen the faith of aspirants and to prevent neophytes from abetment.

All hard core spiritualists trace their lineage back to god the creator . "

"He is the preceptor of even the predecessors since he predates time and outlasts it" says Patanjali, the exponent of yoga philosophy .A guru takes his disciples' awareness beyond time conditioning so he is one with Ishwara, the time transcendent entity i.e the first guru.

सदसदनुग्रहनिग्रहगृहीतमुनिविग्रहोभगवान्

दंड कमंडलु खर्परकंथा मात्रपरिच्छदगात्रकुटुंबः

सर्वासामुपनिषदां दुर्वासा जयति देशिकःप्रथमः

खण्डनमण्णतुल्यमतिःसन् वीरमतेरमतेमधुराजः

May sage Durvasa the first master of all Upanishads be ever victorious .He is the lord who has incarnated as an ascetic in order to relinquish falsehood and redeem the true ones.

Madhuraj as per his own description appears to be as it were , a Brahmin ascetic who usually carry a holy staff and a coco de mar pot for the ablution. A patched quilt for warding off cold is also common among ancient ordained yogins.

The propitiatory verse is devoted to Durvasa, the penultimate master of the tryambaka lineage. I remember having read the following verse in some version of Tripura mahimna stotra whose authorship is attributed to Durvasa. Which one precedes whom is hard to tell but Sage Durvasa has been unequivocally proclaimed as the first and the foremost preceptor of all Agamas referred to as Upanishads (esoteric wisdom) in this canto .

A begging bowl and just his body paying no heed to doctrinal debates, remaining nonchalant, Madhuraj rejoices in the path of the brave ones” (or may be Veershaiva)

The author of 'Gurunathparamarsh' seems to have reverted to less orthodox alternatives due to his meagre competence or any other private reason of his own . His succour was the great Kashmiri genius Mahamaheshwar Abhinavgupta . He joined him as a septuagenarian and learned from him for full four years . This is the age when an ascetic enters the fourth stage of life i.e. monk hood .

The lineage of tryambak or ardh tryambak cloister is believed to have started from Shrikantha- the shiva and his immediate disciple Durvasa also known as krodhmuni or the "irate mendicant" . Madhuraj felicitates him as the primordial preceptor of all Upanishads . Agamic and Tantric canons were also categorised as Upanishads since agama are claimed to be the appendices of Brahmananda or esoteric wisdom portion of the revelations .The viva voice tradition of the propagation of spirituality as we have mentioned above, remained untainted by any dialectic exposition and the guru used to induce his spiritual energy into the novice without any physical communication of any form . The Kashmir school of tantras is one such a lineage. All doctrines based on cognitive reasoning like syllogism and meemansa etc are conditioned in the realm of Vidya and cannot transcend the limits of objective experience .

The doctrine of Ishwarapratyabhijna is too introvert and transcendental that identifying one self with any varna or ashrams is disparaged (पूर्वजात्यपरिज्ञानम्) one must forget his preceding genus in toto .

Madhuraj seems to have crossed the stage where retaining or letting go of the conventional identification with ones gross body made no difference . He was an अत्याश्रमी (who has transcended all stages of life)in the guise of an अंत्याश्रमी an ordained Brahmin monk .

श्रीवसुगुप्तमहागुरुसोमानंदप्रभूत्पलाचार्यान्

We are rendering a few cantos from Madhuraja's 'Guruparamarsh' to have a glimpse of Abhinavgupta's magnanimity from the perspective of one of his intimate disciples who was fortunate enough to be in his proximity ,physically as well as spiritually .

अभिनवगुप्तनाथं वन्दे श्रीक्षेमराजं च -२

I make obeisance to lord Abhinavgupta and Kshemraj, the great master Vasugupta, lord Somananda and Utpalacharya.

The mystic team of Abhinavgupta included all his contemporary adepts ,disciples and preceding preceptors

The third fourth ,fifth and sixth verses give us a vivid and picturesque view of the niche of the great mystic scholar. .Madhuraj, with his poetic ingenuity has made his preceptor's image perpetually imprinted in the hearts of the followers of Abhinavgupta through this pen picture .

द्राक्षारामस्यमध्ये स्फटिकमणिमयेमंडपेचित्ररम्ये

पुष्पस्रग्धूपदीपैर्बहुलपरिमलेचर्चितेचंदनाढ्यैः

वाद्यैर्गीतैः सनृत्तैः सततमुखरितैः योगिनीसिद्धसंघैः

राकीर्णैः स्वर्णपीठे मृदुतमविलसद्बद्धमुक्ताविताने

आसीनः क्षेमराजपृभृतिभिरखिललैः सेवितः शिष्यवर्गैः

पादोपांते निषण्णैः अवहितहृदयैः मुक्तमुक्तं लिखद्भिः

द्वाभ्यां पार्श्वस्थिताभ्यां शिवरसकरकंपूर्णतांबूलपेटिं

दूतीभ्यां विभ्रतीभ्यामपरकरसलन्मातुलुंगोत्पलाभ्याम्

आनंदांदोलिताक्षस्फुटकृतिलको भस्मनाभालमध्ये

रुद्राक्षोल्लासिकर्णः कलितकचभरो मालयालंबकूर्चः

रक्तांगोयक्षपंकोलसदसितगलोलंबमुक्तोपवीतः

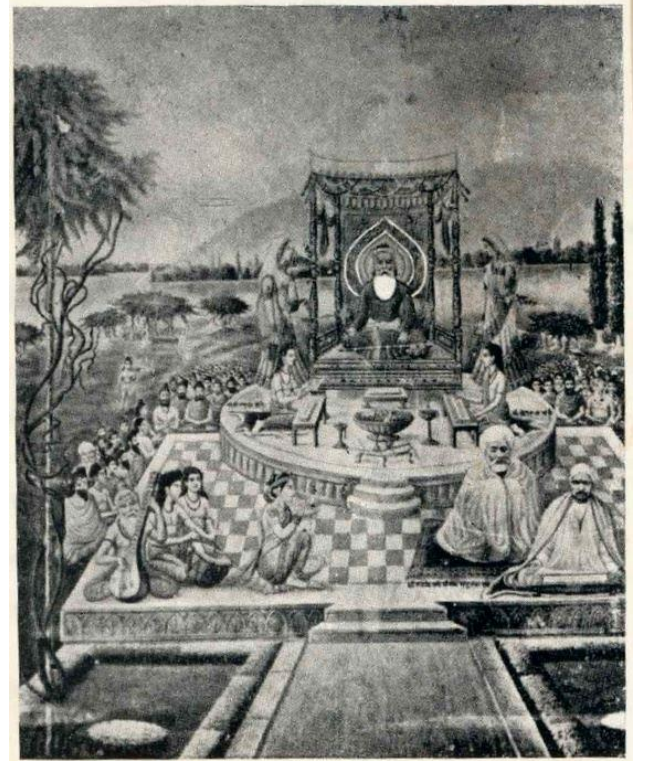
क्षौमं वासो वसानः शशिकरधवलं वीरयोगासनस्थः

जान्वासक्तैकहस्तः स्फुटपरमशिवज्ञानमुद्राक्षत्रो

वामश्रीपाणीपद्मस्फुरितनखमुखैर्वादयन्नादवीणाम्

शरीकंठेशावतारः परमकरुणया प्राप्तकाश्मीरदेशः

श्रीमान्नः पातु साक्षादभिनववपुषादक्षिणामूर्तिदेवः



Abhinavaguptācārya
(: the Gurunātha)
[Tenth Century A. D.]

Within a vineyard there is a crystal dias and a golden seat adorns it . The seat is shaded by soft delicate curtains studded with pearls. This place is all colourful with floral decor, incense lamp and smeared with fragrant sandal paste ,echoing with music of various instruments singing and dancing . It is thronged by bands of yoginis and adepts .

My great master adorns a throne with all his disciples encircling him . His scribes sitting near the pedestal taking his dictation .Two maids ,one with a jar of Shiva liquor and a box of beetle nuts where as the other with a citrus and lotus stand on his either side .

My guru's eyes are resplendent with ecstatic bliss ,a beautiful conspicuous triple streak of the holy ash on his forehead looks so beautiful . Rudraksha beads adorn his ears ,hair and as long dangling necklace .The fragrant reddish anointment of myrrh smeared on his throat looks dark .His sacred thread is long , he is fair like rays of the moon draped in silken robes and he always sits in veerasanam posture .

जान्वासक्तैकहस्तःस्फुटपरमशिवज्ञानमुद्राक्षसूत्रो

वामश्रीपाणिपद्मस्फुरितनखमुखैर्वादयन्नादवीणां

श्रीकण्ठेशावतारपरमकरुणयाप्राप्तकाश्मीरदेशः

श्रीमान्नःपातुसाक्षादभिनववपुषा दक्षिणामूर्तिदेवः 6

With his one hand resting on his knees carrying a rosary of Rudraksha beads he displays the mudra of imparting the knowledge of param shiva . With his left hand he plays the nad Veena . May lord Daxinamurti the incarnation of shrikantha who has reached Kashmir out of great compassion (by his new manifestation) or in the form of Abhinava redeem us.

May the great master Abhinavgupta -the Kashmiri be victorious who is incarnated for well being of all the world . His speech is accomplished and pure . It's splendour in the form of word and meaning pervades all the six adhvas.

Even the ambrosia offered to us by demigods is not tasty to us who are given to relishing the dictum -the great nectar of eloquence of Abhinavguru.

We have no faith in adoring insentient entities like a holy pitcher ,paintings on canvas or relics and icons made from glass ,stone ,copper or gold . Since we have realised our self as the ultimate god within our own hearts, by the benevolence of the "newly embodied great lord" I.e. Abhinavparameshwara (a play on the word Abhinav)

From fifth to eighteenth verse Madhurajyogi compares his preceptors wisdom and declamation to elixir compared to which even the heavenly encore is merely vinegar . My gurus wisdom he says in the next verse is like a mountain top from where even a massive elephant looks like a mosquito. With world as fragrant with the odour of Abhinavguru's wisdom Indra dislikes the aroma of harichandanam -the divine sandal in his heavenly garden .How can there be even talks of heat and darkness in this world that is cooled down and illumined by the broadcast rays of the wisdom of the moon of Abhinavgupta.

After tasting the elixir of shaivite monism which emanated from the mouth of our preceptor ,we roam happily free from the discipline of animistic subjugation as we have shredded the fetters befitting beasts .

Our spiritual grandeur is spontaneous and unhindered since we ,the knower of our essential nature ,are rich in the wisdom imparted to us by Abhinavgupta that always vibrates within the cavity of our hearts.

The yogi goes on to say that how he has no more faith in adoring gross insentient entities like a jar,thanka painting ,idols and relics made from Copper gold and stone etc. Since by the grace of lord abhinavgupta we behold our self within our hearts as the self of all gods and demigods .

Madhuraj in a couple of verses pinpoints some of gurus works like panchashika ,kathamukh mahatilakam, which is a treatise on old Nyaya.

Since the poet says that it contains all sixteen definitions of nyaya school and is aimed at subjugating his contemporary doctrinal rivals this is perhaps one of the unavailable works of Abhinavgupta .

अभिनवगुप्तनाथलिखितंलिखितंहृदये

तदितरशास्त्रकारलिखितंलिखितंसलिले

स्वहृदयदेवतामुखहुतंहतमग्निमुखे

तदितरदेवतासुनिहितंनिहितंभसिते

Praising the writ of his master, he says that his utterances enter his novices hearts and are literally engraved there where as the words of all other so called preceptors vanish as if they were written on the water . Oblations made into the mouth of god residing within your heart amounts to oblations put into the sacrificial fire .On the other hand oblations made for any other Demi god except the universal self goes waste like oblations put into ashes .

मनसैवगम्यतेया परिपंथिनएवपालकायस्यां

प्रतिपदविश्रांतिमयीपद्धतिरियमभिनवाजयति।31

The wonderful path of Abhinavgupta is ever victorious ,which is trodden mentally I.e. Without any physical effort and even the looters in this path sustain the aspirant . In this miraculous path one rests after every single step .This is a play on the word Pade. After every step or after each word there is vishranti or a seat in ones essential nature .

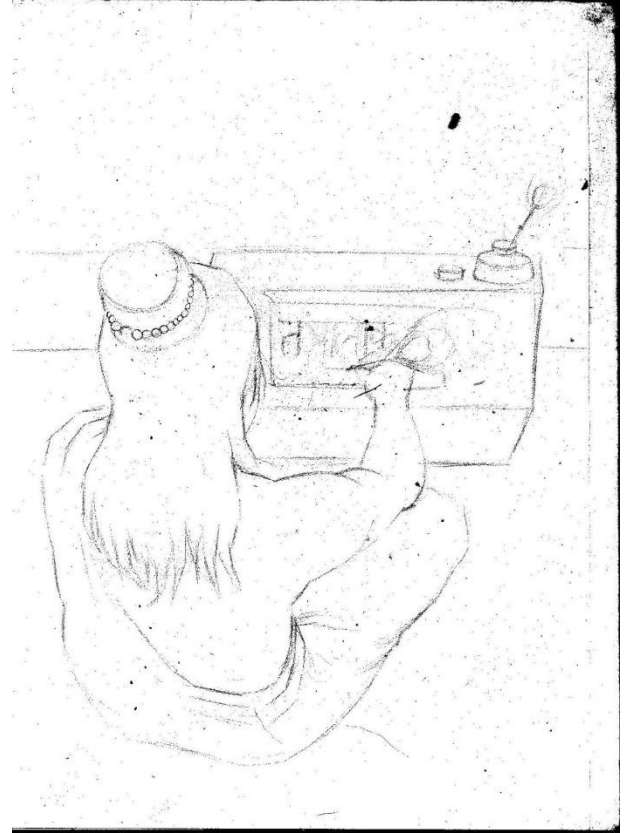
It doesn't matter says the poet-ascetic ,wether the wise ones reject me or applauded me ,no man no matter how much learned can be more efficient than my guru in ascertaining the essential nature of Shiva .

This humble docile disciple of Maheshwara Abhinavgupta has not only felicitated his master ingeniously but has also set up a trend among the future aspirants of ishwara monism regarding the teacher and taught unison .Owing to his intuitive insight into his own shivahood Madhuraja too will remain as worshipful as his preceptor Abhinavgupta whom he adores as shiva the guru I.e. Dakshinamurthy .

गुरुशिष्यपदेस्थित्वा स्वयमेव सदाशिवः
संप्रदायक्रमाद्भूमौ तंत्रं समवतारयत् ।

Sadashiv alone incarnates in the form of the pupil and the preceptor to propagate the lineage of this arcane cult of shaivite monism .

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Quintessence of the highest Purpose: A translation, introduction and analysis of SriAbhbinavagupta's Paramarthsara

(Section of the text sans references: Complete paper published in Journal of Indian Research, Vol 1, No.4, Oct-Dec 2013)

Dr. Jeffrey S. Lidke

ABSTRACT

Abhinavagupta (ca. 975-1025 C.E.) is the greatest synthesizer of Indian Tantric thought and practice. His works influenced and shaped theoretical paradigms in the field of Indian aesthetics, Tantra, literature, and philosophy. In this paper, the author examines the 105 verses of Abhinavagupta's Paramārthasāra (Quintessence of the Highest Purpose) in which Abhinavagupta articulates his philosophy of absolute monism, known popularly as Kashmir Śaivism. An earlier Paramārthasāra was composed by the South Indian legendary saint, Ādiśeṣa during the sixth century, some four hundred years before Abhinavagupta. Abhinavagupta's reinvention of this older text indicates the constant transaction of ideas between Kashmir and South India, Vaiṣṇavite and Śaivite sects. The present shape of Indian thought emerged

only as a result of the fusion and appropriation of different thought-streams. A translation of the Paramārthasāra along with an introduction into Abhinavagupta's Monistic Śaivism has been herewith attempted.

Keywords: ābhāsa, Anuttara, kuṇḍalinī-śakti, Paramaśiva, Para Samvit, sahāsrāra, satguru, tattva, Trika, twilight language.

Introduction

The writings of the famous Tāntric guru and philosopher, Abhinavagupta (ca. 975-1025 C.E.), represent some of the finest reflections of Indian religio-philosophical thought. Of his many extant works, the Paramārthasāra (Quintessence of the Highest Purpose) offers a succinct distillation of Abhinavagupta's literary and philosophical genius while also encapsulating the system of esoteric practices at the heart of his Tāntric system. The one-hundred-and-five verses of this composite text lay out the śaivite vision of the universe as the unfolding of a unitary consciousness, called verily Paramaśiva, Para Samvit, Caitanya, Cit Śakti, and Anuttara. Through a process of hierarchical manifestation, this Supreme Principle assumes the form of thirty-six evolutes (tattvas), and in this way, projects the universe of

diverse objects upon its own screen. At the core of this universal projection, the absolute assumes the form of the limited human experiencer. Veiling itself with the three cloaks (trimala), Paramaśiva assumes self-limitation (saṅkocana). Yet, this contracted experience is only temporary. Through the awakening of coiled power (kuṇḍalinī-śakti) received in Tantric initiation (dīkṣā) the limited agent (kartā) internally ascends the ladder of tattvas and reclaims his status as the omnipotent Absolute.

In this essay, I have attempted to illuminate how the Paramārthasāra serves as a guide for this process of the awakening and internal ascension of kuṇḍalinī-śakti. Towards this end, I have rendered my own translation of the text and have written a brief introduction and commentary with the aim of framing for the reader the context in which Abhinavagupta penned his masterful text. In this way it is hoped that my essay serves as an introduction to both the text and the Trika-Kaula tradition in which it arises. By tracing the history of this tradition, and by analyzing its fusion of philosophy and practice in the context of tantric sādhana, I hope to provide an illuminating glimpse into one of the most gifted minds in the history of Indian civilization.

Contextualizing The Text

As a guide for this voyage into the uncharted realm of Tantric practice, we will follow the map drawn by Abhinavagupta in his condensed text, the Paramārthasāra (PS). In 105 ārya-ghaṭa verses, this cryptic and highly codified text details the fourfold path (upāya-catuṣṭayam) to realization (śivattva).

The first English rendering of this text appeared in 1910 in an article entitled “The Paramarthasara of Abhinava-Gupta” by L. D. Barnett.¹ In the preface to this outdated yet useful translation, Barnett writes that his intention in publishing the PS is part of a further project in proving that the “living faith of the majority of modern Tamils is in almost every respect...the same doctrine that was taught in Kashmir about the beginning of the eleventh century by Abhinavagupta.”² This argument for a connection between southern and northern śaiva traditions is clearly strengthened by the fact that Abhinavagupta’s work is based on an earlier southern text of the same name.³ Interestingly, this sixth century text, also

known as the Ādhārakārikā, is authored by a South Indian Vaiṣṇavite Guru, Ādiśeṣa, known more popularly as Patañjali, the legendary incarnation of Viṣṇu’s serpentine companion and the famous author of multiple important Sanskrit works. That Abhinavagupta based his 10th-century śaiva text on this early work suggests not only that there was a shared corpus of texts between the North and South, but also a shared philosophical and practical basis among the numerous traditions then present in Kashmir.

As Silburn points out, this unifying basis was the Sāṃkhya -Yoga system. Ādiśeṣa’s PS is essentially a Sāṃkhya text overlaid with Vaiṣṇava theology. It borrows the classic Sāṃkhya dualism of contentless consciousness (puruṣa) and materiality (prakṛti), while reframing it in the context of Viśiṣṭādvaita.

The Trika-kaula as a Tradition of experience (anubhavasampradāya)

While Abhinavagupta’s PS is clearly an adaptation of this earlier text, we would be unwise to follow Chatterji’s lead in labeling it as “only the Ādhāra-Kārikās with a few alterations here and there.” In fact, only a quarter of Abhinavagupta’s 105 verses directly parallel the Ādiśeṣa text. The remaining three-quarters are an expression of Abhinavagupta’s own Trika-Kaula system and have no direct counterpart in the older text. For this reason Abhinavagupta states that his purpose is not simply to transcribe the Ādhārakārikās verbatim, but to elucidate them in “accord with the tenets of Trika-śaiva philosophy.”⁴

Interestingly, taking into account the frequent double intentionality of Tantric “twilight language” (sandhā-bhāṣā), this same verse can also be understood to mean that Abhinavagupta has written the PS “in accord with [his] yogic intuition of śaiva doctrine.” The crucial word in the text is dṛṣṭi (√dṛś, “to see”). Chatterji translates it as a synonym of darśana, or philosophical system,⁵ while Barnett renders it as “mystic vision.”⁶ Certainly, these are not mutually exclusive renderings, but rather equally valid and important translations of dṛṣṭi.⁷ Taken together, they reveal an essential feature of Indian philosophy: namely, its direct relation to direct experience (anubhava).⁸ In other words, in the context

of Indian philosophizing, “spiritual vision” is often the logical precursor to a “philosophical system”; consequently, one’s own direct experience (anubhava) is a necessary and logical prerequisite to the writing of a philosophical treatise. Hence, we are to interpret Abhinavagupta’s use of the word “*dr̥ṣṭi*” as a conscious attempt to appropriate its polyvalency. In other words, his intention is to show that his capacity to elucidate the principles of śaiva philosophy (darśana) resides precisely in his own yogic perception (*dr̥ṣṭi*) attained through *sādhana*.

This interpretation would clearly be in line with Abhinavagupta’s own epistemological views that direct experience (anubhava) forms the apex of the three-fold means of correct knowledge (pramāṇa), whose base is scripture (āgama) and the word of the guru (yukti).⁹ Indeed, Abhinavagupta considers Tantra to be a “tradition based on experience” (anubhavasampradāya).¹⁰ Thus, the significance of the third verse of the PS is not only that it establishes the text’s relation to an older scripture, but, more importantly, the author’s own attainment.¹¹ For this reason, Abhinavagupta’s Trika-Kaula deserves to be viewed not solely as fuel for the fires of philosophical abstraction (tarkajvāla), but rather as a practical system “providing a viable means for the attainment of mokṣa.”¹²

Abhinavagupta as adhikārin

In the final chapters of his *Tantrāloka*, Abhinavagupta narrates the special circumstances of his birth. Desiring to parent a siddha, or perfected being, Abhinavagupta’s parents—Narasimhagupta and Vimalā—performed an esoteric ritual. Consequently, when Abhinavagupta entered the world nine months later he was viewed not as an ordinary child, but as a yoginībhū, a special child conceived from the union of a siddha and a yoginī during the course of Tantric ritual. Due to the extraordinary circumstances of his birth and the rich devotional environs of his childhood, Abhinavagupta readily acquired mastery of a wide array of subjects ranging from Buddhist doctrine to śaiva Tantra, to grammar and poetry. However, according to Abhinavagupta, the apex and culmination of learning came through his “studies” with the Kaula guru, Śambhunāth. It was from this

teacher that Abhinavagupta received initiation into the esoteric Kula lineage. In this initiation he received the descent of power (śaktipāta) which produced a condition of embodied liberation (jīvan-mukta).¹³

Regardless of the authenticity of this autobiographical account, the fact that Abhinavagupta is compelled to narrate it in his magnum opus, the *TĀ*, suggests the prominent status of Tantric practice in his philosophical thought. As if compelled to justify his qualification for composing the *TĀ*, an authoritative synthesis of Tantric doctrine and practice, Abhinavagupta asserts that his authority lay in the very fact that he is quite simply a product of Tantra. Tantra is not something he learned solely from books, but is a practice that radically conditioned his birth and, later, produced his final enlightenment. In other words, in no uncertain terms Abhinavagupta is stating, “This doctrine is not simply something I have thought about; rather, it is a reality I have become.” Logically, then, his emphasis is not on providing intellectual stimulation, but on transmitting his own experience and knowledge (jñāna). For this reason, he states clearly that his duty as a teacher is to awaken his disciples.¹⁴

Ultimately, as Müller-Ortega, points out, Abhinavagupta’s teachings are to be seen as a method of realization leading to a state in which one “becomes something that moves in the Heart (hṛdayaṅgamībhūta).”¹⁵ This state of inner absorption is something that, as Abhinavagupta himself points out, transcends the limits of language and for this reason the scholar attempting an exegesis of the Trika-Kaula, is bound to confront an intriguing hermeneutical challenge. Addressing this matter Müller-Ortega asks rhetorically:

Can we completely hope to understand Abhinavagupta?...[In attempting to do so] [W]e immediately encounter an important and central cross-cultural perplexity. We have been using the term understand in its commonly accepted denotation: to have a thorough technical acquaintance with something. The term may be used in a stronger sense: Abhinavagupta distinguishes between an understanding that is purely intellectual, and one

gained from experiential knowledge. There is an important sense in which to understand the Heart actually requires replicating the journey of return that is the tantric sādhana: we must play Śiva's game to its most serious and hilarious conclusion, which is the unmasking of Śiva within ourselves.¹⁶

As Müller-Ortega himself points, this type of radical understanding challenges the traditional paradigms of western scholarship. Still, the scholar of Tantra ought not ignore the fact that much of Tantric thought stems from and is geared towards contemplative experiences. In other words, much of Tantric thought is properly classified as pertaining to the realms of spiritual practice and its concomitant experiences. Does this mean that we should accept Frits Staal's bold assertion that to understand practice-based ritual traditions the scholar himself must learn the logic of its practice?¹⁷ Abhinavagupta's unequivocal answer would be "yes".

However, Abhinavagupta's views would perhaps not fare well in the post-enlightenment environs of 21st-century academia. The deeply entrenched demand for scholarly distance and objectivity perhaps does not allow for the kind of full-bodied engagement that Abhinavagupta demanded of his own students. However, the equally important demand for hermeneutical accuracy necessitates a proper contextualizing of Abhinavagupta's system. In other words, although as scholars we may feel duty-bound not to practice sādhana, we are obligated nonetheless to be sensitive to the practice-based nuances of Abhinavagupta's densely coded writings.

This is not to say that pure philosophical inquiry has no place in the PS for such a statement would be far from the truth. Abhinavagupta's stature in Indian history is primarily due to his great gift for verbal expression. In a way unparalleled by any one prior to him, he was able to formalize the numerous esoteric streams of Tantra into a single, unified river of thought and practice. On this grand achievement Kamalakar Mishra writes:

Abhinavagupta presents the otherwise difficult philosophy of Tantra in a cogent and coherent way that makes the Tantric position logically and

rationally acceptable. What is complex in Tantra becomes simple in his treatment; what is esoteric and mystical becomes rationally understandable.¹⁸

Abhinavagupta's cogent systematization stems from his own initiation and training in the various lineages and philosophical schools (sampradāya) of his time. In other words, Abhinavagupta's philosophy is not the product of a single line of thought; rather, it is a rich synthesis of the multiple indoctrinations he pursued during the years of his own sādhana. In his person, the plethora of Tantric schools were united through the intensity of his own critical insight and fused into a single system in which the practices and philosophical views of the various schools were grouped as a hierarchy of ascending powers culminating with the esoteric branch of Āgamic Tantrism known now as Trika-Kaula, "The Family of the Triad".¹⁹ And it was this ability to unify the plurality of Śaivism into a single doctrinal system that makes Abhinavagupta's work so intriguing. Before his time, there was no single tradition. Rather, as Alper has pointed out, there were only "a series of overlapping preceptorial lines, and a plenitude of spiritual techniques available to each teacher."²⁰ Hence, it was through Abhinavagupta's teachings that these numerous techniques and lineages were subsumed within a larger theoretical framework that embraced them all. And it is this carefully crafted framework that is now commonly referred to as Kashmir Śaivism.²¹ Although, historically speaking, there never was a Kashmir Śaivism, the fact that scholars now look at the traditions of Kashmir as a unified whole is due largely to Abhinavagupta (perhaps, then, the appropriate term would be "Abhinavagupta-ism"). For this reason no text better captures Abhinavagupta's gift-for-synthesis than the Paramārthasāra. A careful study of this brief yet dense text enables us to unpack the many levels of teachings and techniques he received and thereby appreciate the way in which he fuses them into a single Tantric "river".²²

This introduction to the PS is intended to guide the reader through the multiple initiatory streams that Abhinavagupta himself journeyed in the course of his sādhana. In this way we can come to see that these streams-of-revealed-thought-and-practice were

viewed by Abhinavagupta as ultimately united in a larger river-of-divine-consciousness that itself flows from and returns ever again into the infinite sea of radical freedom. The key to successfully charting this voyage lies in identifying the PS as a map for this most majestic of journeys. This text's purpose, as Abhinavagupta clearly states, is to guide the aspirant through the ascending levels of consciousness until there is the realization of one's identity with the Highest Purpose (paramārtha). It is along this route to the final destination that Tantric aspirant, or sādḥaka, ontologically encounters the various philosophical systems as inner states of consciousness and being. In other words, in the initial stages of sādḥana, when one's consciousness is still mired by dualistic thought patterns (dvaitavikalpa), the teachings of the dualistic scriptures (dvaitāgama) are necessary. However, as one advances in sādḥana, one's internal ascension is paralleled externally by initiation (dīkṣā) into scriptural traditions which claim to grant states of non-dual awareness. Hence, in the external world there is a plurality of teachings and spiritual techniques. Yet, in the inner life of the sādḥaka these distinctions are fused in a process of internal bodily ascension.

To understand the mechanisms of this ascension we must first come to grips with the central philosophical systems embedded in the PS and the principle tenets that undergird Abhinavagupta's thought. Constructing these tenets as our boat, we will then be ready to explore the vast, mysterious waters of sādḥana that Abhinavagupta charts in the latter third of his treatise on the Quintessence of the Highest Purpose.

The Tantric Streams

Abhinavagupta's Tantric Trika-Kaula 'river-system' is a careful re-channeling of four scriptural streams. One stream is the ancient Āgamic Śaivism, itself fed by three smaller tributaries based, respectively, on dualism (dvaita), dual-cum-non-dualism (dvaitādvaita), and non-dualism (advaita). A second stream is the Pratyabhijñā which receives its currents from both Āgamic waters and from the philosophical tributaries of Vedānta. The third stream, the Spanda, is similar to the Pratyabhijñā, in that while its source is the Āgamas it then branches off on a different course before being redirected by Abhinavagupta. The

fourth stream appears to be fed not only by the Āgamas, but from various sources ranging from Tamil Nādu in the South to Nepal in the North. This poly-sourced stream-of-revelation is the Kaula tradition with its emphasis on radical antinomian practices (called "left-handed", vāmācāra) as a means to immediate salvation. Of the many Kaula streams, there are two that flowed directly into Abhinavagupta's system: the goddess-centered cults of the Krama and the Trika. Apparently, Abhinavagupta experienced the Kaula waters as the most satisfying, for he claimed the Kaula to be the pinnacle of all traditions. And of the many streams that fed the Kaula system, he saw Trika as the greatest. In his words, Trika was to the Kaula as fragrance to a rose—its finest essence.²³ Hence, Abhinavagupta proclaimed his philosophy to be Trika-Kaulism. As we have seen, this Trika-Kaula river results from the confluence not just of the Trika and Kaula, but from the Āgama, Pratyabhijñā, and Spanda streams as well.

Commencing The Journey into The highest purpose

The opening verse of the PS crystallizes the Trika śaivas' paradoxical conception of the Śiva, the Trika-Kaula Absolute. Here, Abhinavagupta honors Śiva as the "one without beginning" who "dwells manifoldly in secret places" as "the receptacle of all."²⁴ In other words, for the Kaśmirī Tāntrikas, the Absolute is simultaneously one and many. Endowed with unlimited power (śakti), the Supreme Principle can manifest itself infinitely without losing its essential unity. For this reason, the universe, though appearing divided, is really only the flashing forth (ābhāsa) of the One. Abhinavagupta writes (PS 4-5):

This sphere (aṇḍa, cosmic egg) ...is brought forth by the Lord through the bestowal of his innate power and might. This universe with its succession of manifold bodies, organs and worlds is within these spheres; and therein is the enjoyer, the embodied Śiva who assumes the condition of creatures.

In other words Śiva contains within Himself the ability to manifest distinctions within unity (bhedābheda). Yet, just as a crystal remains untainted by the various hues it adopts, so the Absolute remains

one despite its appearance in the form of “gods, humans, animals, and plant-life” (PS 6).

The process of universal manifestation is elaborately explained by the Trika system through the doctrine of the thirty-six evolutes or tattvas. The supreme reality—called Paramaśiva, Para Samvit, Caitanya—is pure consciousness beyond the sphere of manifestation. In reference to its transcendent-ness Abhinavagupta refers to the Absolute as the “thirty-seventh tattva” in the TĀ.²⁵ Yet, this transcendent principle is also the ocean of consciousness out of which creation arises. For unlike the Vedāntin conception of Brahman as static consciousness, the Trika Śaiva absolute embodies both consciousness (caitanya) and dynamism or spanda-śakti. Acting as an inner pulse, the spanda-śakti unfolds the universe of tattvas within the body of the absolute (PS 10). Hence, in the Trika schema, the transcendent contains the manifest. And even during the time of cosmic manifestation, the supreme principle (para-tattva) remains “free of delusion, pure, peaceful and beyond creation and dissolution” (PS 11).

This capacity for internal self-manifestation is explained through a dialectic of illumination and reflection (prakāśa/vimarśa). Indeed, the Absolute is characterized as being endowed with these two principles (prakāśa-vimarśa-śakti). The Absolute embodies not only an illuminating consciousness, but also a reflective capacity for self-knowledge that plays out on all levels of manifestation. At the cosmogonic level, prakāśa is the first tattva, the śivatattva, and vimarśa is the second, the śaktitattva. These two, śiva and śakti, are understood to be the Lord (Tīvara) and his consort, devī. In Tantric cosmogonic schemes the union of Śiva and Śakti gives rise to creation; and in a philosophical context the union of these two principles is the fusing of a knowing agent (pramāṭṛ) with the means of knowing (pramāṇa) which necessitates the need for a source of objective knowledge (prameya). Hence, in cosmogonic terms the prameya is the very universe itself, for the product of the union of śiva and śakti, prakāśa and vimarśa, pramāṭṛ and pramāṇa, is the additional thirty-four tattvas that form the basis of objective manifestation.

The key to understanding Trika-Kaula discourse is to realize that the prakāśa-vimarśa dialectic plays out at

all levels of reality. Another way to say this is that each of the lower tattvas incorporates within itself those tattvas that precede it. Hence, even the lowest tattvas, the elemental substances (pañca-mahābhūta), contain within themselves the essence of the tattvas from even the most subtle stages of creation. Hence, the principle of illumination (prakāśa) and self-reflection (vimarśa) are present at all levels of creation. In other words, all objects (prameyas) are constituted of prakāśa and vimarśa and for this reason Abhinavagupta claims that the knower, the means of knowing, and the object known comprise a triune Self. It is in this spirit that the Tantras state that there is nothing that is not Śiva.²⁶ Hence, the world itself, when properly understood becomes a basis for mystical realization. Indeed, the higher states of sādhana are said to consist in the awareness that the world itself is composed of the bliss experienced in yogic samādhi.²⁷ There is, in other words, no need to meditate in caves: the highest realization can just as easily be apprehended while doing such mundane things as sipping chai (Indian tea).

Abhinavagupta gives a potent metaphor for this extrovertive samādhi in his comparison of the relationship of the universe to the absolute with that of reflected images to a mirror:

Just as the images of a town, a village, and other objects reflected in a mirror appear inseparable from the mirror yet appear distinct both from one another and from the mirror, in the same way, arising from the absolute consciousness of Para Bhairava, this universe, though inherently void of divisions, nevertheless appears internally apportioned and distinct [from Para Bhairava] (PS 12-13).

In this multilayered metaphor there are three important elements: the objects (nagaragrāmādi), the reflections, and the mirror itself (darpaṇa). The relationship between them reveals both the fundamental principles of prakāśa and vimarśa and the key to understanding śaiva yoga. The mirror itself is Śiva, or pure illumination (prakāśa). Possessing within itself the capacity for revelation (vimarśa), the mirror contains a variety of reflected images. In terms of epistemology, these images are the prameya. The fact of their reflection, which is the means of their

being perceived—hence known—, is the *pramāṇa*, and the mirror is the metaphorical knower (*pramāṭr*).

What is the relationship between the three? The answer to this question is more nuanced than it first appears. On a surface level, the reflected images appear distinct both from one another and from the mirror. In other words, according to conventional reality, one would consider the knower, the known, and means of knowing all distinct. However, as Abhinavagupta states, conventional understanding has no basis at the level of the Supreme Truth (PS 27). For this reason, the true relation of the three is stated to be one of inseparability (*avibhāgin*). Developing this theme of inseparability, Abhinavagupta goes on to equate the mirror with the absolute consciousness of highest Bhairava (*vimalatama-parama-bhairava-bodham*) who, both in terms of the metaphor and Trika cosmology, is the supreme knower (*pramāṭr*).

Now, what is the relationship between Bhairava and the universe? Abhinavagupta answers that despite the appearance of being mutually apportioned and distinct (*vibhaktamābhāti*), the relationship of Bhairava (*pramāṭr*) to the universe (*prameya*) and its reflection (*pramāṇa*)—like that of the mirror to its objects—is one void of distinctions (*vibhāgaśūnyam*). In other words, from the highest perspective, the trinity of epistemological and cosmological principles is a unity. Like the various forms of candy, which are but modifications of syrup, these three are but modifications of the Supreme Self (PS 26).

Bondage And Embodiment

The purpose (*prayojana*) for writing the PS is clearly established by Abhinavagupta in the third verse where he explains that his treatise (*śāstra*) is written in response to the pleas of a disciple caught in the “wheel of suffering that begins with dwelling in the womb and ends with death.” Living in a universe that is inherently devoid of distinctions, being the self-manifestation of omnipotent consciousness, how then can there be an occasion for bondage? Abhinavagupta answers that this condition paradoxically arises as the result of the absolute’s power of freedom (*svātantrya-śakti*). In other words, it is precisely because *Paramaśiva* is unbounded that He/She/It can assume the condition of bondage.

In terms of cosmic emanation, the cause of bondage arises at the level of the sixth *tattva* (*māyā-tattva*). At this level, Consciousness is said to assume the capacity of self-limitation (*saṅkocana*) which makes possible the appearance of duality and multiplicity. The *māyā-tattva* is itself composed of five sheaths (*kañcukas*) which limit the functioning of the five powers (*pañca-śakti*) of the Pure Order (*śuddhādhvan*) (PS 16). What results is the formation of the ‘three taints’ (*trimala*) which encase consciousness and transform it into a limited soul (PS 24).

This limited soul is the twelfth principle, the *puruṣa-tattva*. In verse sixteen Abhinavagupta refers to the *puruṣa* as a “fettered beast” who, due to the influence of *māyā*, has contracted from the condition of pure consciousness (*bodham*) to that of a tainted soul (*malinas*). At this level of the cosmic hierarchy, the Supreme Self, “due to its associations with the darkness of ignorance comes to perceive Itself as a wondrous diversity of subjects and objects.” In other words, at the level of the *puruṣa-tattva*, there is a perceived split between self and other.

And at this stage there unfolds the twenty-four material categories of the classical *Sāmkhya* schema, beginning with *prakṛti* and progressing through the threefold psychic instrument (*antahkāraṇa*)—intellect (*buddhi*), ego (*ahaṃkāra*), and mind (*manas*)—, the organs of knowledge (*buddhīndriya*)—the ear (*śrotra*), the skin (*tvak*) the eye (*cakṣus*), the tongue (*rasana*), and the nose (*ghrāṇa*)—, the organs of action (*karmendriya*)—speech (*vāk*), hands (*pāni*), feet (*pāda*), anus (*payu*), generative organ (*upastha*)—, the five subtle elements (*tanmātra*)—sound (*śabda*), touch (*sparśa*), color (*mahas*), taste (*rasa*) and smell (*gandha*)—, and, lastly, the physical sphere (*sthūla-viśayas*) constituted by the five material elements (*pañca-mahābhūtas*)—sky (*nabhas*), wind (*pavanas*), fire (*tejas*), water (*salila*) and earth (*pṛthvī*) (PS 19-22).

The result of this process is that consciousness takes the form of a body (*dehabhāva*) (PS 23). In other words, according to the Trika, the final result of cosmic manifestation is embodiment. Hence, in this

system, the body is both the product of creation and the receptacle of manifestation itself. Hence, the body contains within itself each of the thirty-six tattvas, and for this reason reflects the structure of the universe.²⁸

Consequently, the tattva schema is to be understood simultaneously as a map of the universe and of the human being--the two, in Tantric circles, being inseparable.²⁹

As we will see below in my translation of Abhinavagupta's Paramārthasāra, in the practices of Trika sādhanā the homologies between the universe and the body play out on several levels. According to Abhinavagupta's Śaivism, the body itself is not the cause of bondage. It is the final product of Paramaśiva's expansive power (unmeṣa-śakti). The true source of bondage is the malas which encase the finite soul (puruṣa, anu) in ignorance (avidyā) and create the experience of cyclical existence or saṃsāra. In such a condition, the limited soul, "like a spider with its web, spins for itself a variegated pattern by means of association with the body, breath, perception, thought, knowledge and the expanse of ether" (PS 32). In other words, while governed by the malas, the tattvas are an apparent source of bondage:

When the multitude of tattvas are unagitated the Lord likewise appears still; likewise is He excited when they are so and bewildered when there is the state of bewilderment. However, in actuality, from the [perspective of the] Highest Truth He is not these conditions (PS 38).

The last line of the above verse is the key to understanding the Trika conception of bondage. It suggests, that ultimately, the entire notion of limitation is a cosmic joke, or play (līla). In the final analysis, Śiva is never bound, and in the moment of this re-cognition (pratyabhijñā), the sādhanā is awakened. At that point, the body becomes the temple of god (devagrha) and delusion is shattered. Then, there is the condition of embodied liberation (jīvan-mukta). Hence, for the Trika śaivite, death is not a prerequisite for final release (videha-mukta).³⁰ Knowledge alone is necessary, for in the moment of awakening there is the understanding that Śiva alone unfolds the drama of bondage and release:

He (the sādhanā) would free his own Self from bondage by means of the splendor of the greatness

of self-knowledge. Thus, the Supreme Śiva unfolds the drama consisting of the wonders of bondage and liberation. (PS 33).

Paradoxically, this moment of re-cognition, this condition of knowing, often requires ritual practices (karman) to produce a condition of purification in which pure knowledge can arise. Consequently, the Trika sādhanā system enjoins the combining of knowledge and action (jñāna-karma-samuccaya-vāda) as a means to freedom. In defense of this position, the Trika defines the absolute as constituted of a triadic power: will (icchā), knowledge (jñāna), and action (kriyā).

The dimensions of sādhanā

Trika theology describes this world as the self-manifestation of an omnipotent and dynamic consciousness. Logically, then, as we have seen, bondage is an impossibility, an illusion or mirage. Yet, there is the experience of suffering and consequently the need for a method (upāya) which brings about the dissolving of the mirage of ignorance. Herein, enters the essential features of Tantra—an elaborate technology of self-release based on a science of the body (dehavidyā). Within this system, abstract philosophical inquiry as found in the initial sections of the PS, forms part of the means to liberating knowledge (jñāna).³¹ In other words, descriptions of the tattvas, the nature of the cosmogonic process, etc., serve not only to satisfy intellectual curiosities, but to finally produce an existential awakening and release. And this condition, the Tantras declare, requires "active ritual participation leading the aspirant to experiential knowledge (bhāvanajñāna)."³²

Hence, for the initiated sādhanā, the PS is to be understood not as representing a philosophical stance to be agreed or disagreed with, but as a guideline for acquiring experiential knowledge that was disseminated within guarded circles of initiation and secrecy. Initiation was understood to be the sine qua non of proper textual exegesis, since it was only through this consecration that the malas could be removed. Through dīkṣā came the descent of power (śaktipāta) which made possible the revelation of the Self. "As the face is revealed in a spotless mirror," writes Abhinavagupta, "so This (Self) is revealed as

light in the mind purified by śaktipāta (PS 9).”

This initiatory transmission was believed to awaken the aspirant’s own dormant power, the kuṇḍalinī-śakti, which, when awakened arose through the central current (suṣumnā-nāḍi), purifying the latent tendencies (samskāras) and uniting the sādḥaka’s limited identity with that of cosmic identity situated at the crown of the head in the saḥsṛāra. This path of internal ascension was called the upward yoga (udmukhyayoga) and was considered the distinctive feature of the Kaula school. In mythological terms, the upward path was the upward face of Śiva’s five-faced icon (pañca-mukha-liṅga). This path removed all ignorance and established the sādḥaka in the highest state of empowerment through the shredding of the malas:

As the chaff surrounding the rice grain seems inseparable and yet is removed, so this (=the trimala) is shed by the upward yoga of the path of Śaivism (PS 18).

For one to enter the path of upward yoga, the essential prerequisite was the meeting with a qualified master (satguru). Contact with the teacher was understood to produce an alchemical process of transformation that liberated the disciple from all impurities (PS 17). Under rare circumstances, the empowerment received from the guru was so intense (atītivra-śaktipāta) it would produce instant enlightenment and the sādḥaka would become “Śiva Himself” (PS 96). More often, however, liberation occurred gradually (karma-mukti) through “ascending the steps of the ladder [of tattvas]” (PS 97).

For a fuller understanding of this process of ascension one can benefit by turning to other texts, both primary and secondary. Quality work in the field of Kashmir Śaivism is now quite established, thanks particularly to scholars like Alexis Sanderson and his kula in the UK, the many American scholars working in the field (Lawrence, White, Skora, Muller-Ortega) as well as a host of Indian paṇḍitas, including Timalisina, Dyckowski, Mishra and others. In particular, one ought to read the Tantrāloka and Tantrasāra in which Abhinavagupta maps out the path to liberation as a fourfold means (upāyacatuśyayam) in which advanced ritual techniques are understood to correspond to the sādḥaka’s own internal state of

cognitive development.

Towards this end one can also reflect on the following translation of the Parmārthasāra, in which I have attempted to capture both the literal power and poetic sweetness of Abhinavagupta’s reflections on the quintessence (sāra) of the highest (parama) purpose (artha). While this brief text does not provide the detail of other works by Abhinavagupta, it nonetheless distills the essence of his spiritual brilliance. Practiced in its own context, the Parmārthasāra is chanted as litany to a ritualized and meditative visualization practice through which the initiate seeks to re-cognize her own identity as the highest purpose (for the objectivized “goal” is inevitably one’s own subjective “self” in Trika-Kaulism). In this state of refined self-as-awareness, purpose (artha), aim (artha) and truth (artha) are all grounded in that Supreme Being who is one’s own self-of-self. With this awareness firmly established, the sādḥaka realizes that, indeed, “I alone am the Deity I worship” (śivo’ham)

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Camatkāra and Abhinavagupta's Aesthetics

Niraj Kumar

Abhinavagupta (10-11th Century AD) was the true genius and polymath who synthesized various strands of Indian thinking. He was a great yogi, philosopher, and master of poetics. Abhinavagupta inherited multiple traditions of knowledge through a large number of gurus mentioned in his magnum opus, *Tantraloka* and altered those fundamentally. In this brief paper, his work on poetics will be discussed and to situate his ideas on aesthetic experience vis-à-vis spiritual experiences.

Abhinavagupta's major works on Sanskrit poetics are the *Locana*, a commentary on Ānandavardhana's *Dhvanyāloka* and the *Abhinavabhāratī*, a commentary on Bharata Muni's *Nāṭyaśāstra*. The *Locana* was written before *Abhinavabhāratī* as there are references about the latter in the former. Abhinavagupta mentions Utpala as his Paramguru in poetics. He also quotes his teachers Bhatta Induraja in both *Locana* and *Abhinavabhāratī* and Bhatta Tauta. Bhatta Tauta is credited with the work, *Kavya Kautuka* on which Abhinavagupta wrote a commentary. But, Abhinavagupta seems to be much influenced by the tripartite formulations of Bhatta Nayaka in *Hridayadarpana*, which appears to have touched deeply his own penchant for trika philosophy.

Before Anandavardana, there were three schools in the field of criticism. Alamkara and Riti school in the poetics and the Rasa school of Bharata in the drama. Bhamah's *Kavyalankara* is considered the first work of Alamkara school. For Bhamaha, "shabdarthau sahita

kavyam" or the words and their meaning, properly matched is the poetry. Bhamaha considered vakratva (deviation from ordinary mode of expression) as the best ornament of poetry. The alamkara school was further developed by the works of Dandin. Riti school was developed by Vamana. Bharat Muni is credited with systemizing the Rasa school in the magnum opus, the *Natyasastra* (4-5th century A.D.). The theory of Rasa was discussed systematically by Bhatta Lollatta, Sankuka and Bhatta Nayaka.

In Indian literary tradition, there are different layers of meanings. There is literal (shabdārtha), indicative (lakshana/metaphoric), purportive (tatparya) meaning. But, dhvani theorists emphasized how there is implicit meaning (vyangyārtha) in every work of literature and art.

Dhvani has three aspects, '*abhidha*' which consists in the literal meaning of the expression, '*laksana*' which consists in the external characteristic of the expression which are indicative of something deeper like metaphors, and '*vyanjana*', the implicative or the suggested meaning. One arrives at the suggested sense either through '*abhidha*' or '*laksana*'. '*Abhidha*' and '*lakshana*' are ways and '*vyanjana*' is the end. Anandavardhana in *Dhvanyāloka* takes up three main types of implicit (suggested) sense namely - '*vastu dhvani*', '*alankaara dhvani*', and '*rasa dhvani*'. In '*vastu dhvani*', some rare fact or idea is implied. In '*alankaara dhvani*' some alankaara or figure of speech is suggested. In '*rasa dhvani*', rasa is evoked. Rasa dhvani can never be expressed in the direct meaning of words.

For , Anandavardana "The soul of poetry is dhvani". He explains the predominance of dhvani in the poetry by the use of the term *lavanya* (grace) :

"The word power of the poet in a poem has an overall charm just as a young woman has an overall charm not discernible in her limbs taken separately."

Abhinavagupta inherited Anandavardana's theory of dhvani along with its criticism by Bhatta Nayaka who emphasized more on the realization of Rasa.

Abhinavagupta accepted Anandavardana's categorization of dhvani and added certain categories himself. Abhinavagupta reinterpreted the theory from the fundamental question. What is Dhvani? '*Dhvanat*

iti dhvani ', that which sounds or resonates or implies is dhvani. '*Dhvanyate iti dhvani*' or dhvani is what is sounded or reverberated or implied. Abhinavagupta accepts the three-fold classification of dhvani. But, he brings in his own criteria for the same- *laukika* and *alaukika*. *Laukika* is what one encounters in everyday life, But, the other is '*kaavya vyaapaara gocara*' and *alaukika*. It is to be found only in poetry. The *laukika* dhvani in poetry is also two-fold; *vastu dhvani* and *alankara dhvani*. In these two cases, the *laukika* dhvani is manifest. But, in poetry only, *rasa dhvani* can be found. Abhinavagupta holds that *rasa dhvani* alone constitutes the soul of poetry. Both *vastu dhvani* and *alankaara dhvani* are the ways but *rasa dhvani* is the summum bonum of poetic experience.

Language that manifests the meaning explicitly lacks emotion or suggestion and cannot constitute poetry. One can take an example. In the sentence, "The beloved concealed the clothes and she was searching her dress frantically." There is no suggestion. But, if the same is stated in following words, "The thief of heart stole her clothes" suggest the implicit. This also produces erotic *rasa* in the listener. It reaches the implicative or the suggestive sphere also known as *vyanjana*. Dhvani is primarily applied to that poetry where the implicated sense is a *rasa*, *alamkara*(metaphor) or *Vastu*(object). (Dhvanyaloka, I.13). For Abhinavagupta, it is only when dhvani suggests a *Rasa*, that a poetry can be said to be the first rate poetry. This is the *Rasadhvani*. If Anandavardana enunciated that the dhvani is the soul of poetry, Abhinavagupta argued that *Rasa* is the soul of dhvani.

Rasa theory

Rasa is the essence, juice, sap of plant. The term was known during the Vedic times. In Indian culinary, the separation of oil and the *rasa* of the preparation is the sign of generation of taste in food. Suddenly, the colour of the whole changes and the taste that emerges is quite different than that of the constituents. Similarly, chewing betel leaf is part of Indian culture since ancient days. The chewing (*carvana*) of the betel leaf along with lime, catechu, areca nut produces *rasa*, something quite different in colour or taste than any of the constituent. But, the concept of *rasa* gradually became subtler. In *Nirvana Sutra*, Kashyapa addresses Buddha in following words:

"Buddha, like the juice of sugarcane which yields various flavours when boiled various times, I listen to the Buddha speak."

Bodhisattva is often compared with sugarcane:

"The great Bodhisattva is like sugarcane or sesame which, when pressed with a device, gives forth juice or oil". (Kieschnick, p.251).

By the 4th-5th century, the alchemy developed as a full fledged science. The whole discourse of alchemy revolved around the *rasa*. It is also known as the *Rasayan*...path of *Rasa*. But, in contrast to the juicy nature of *Rasa*, the alchemists termed the ashes of different metals and gems as *rasa*. Mercury ash was termed as the *rasadhiraj*. *Rasa* was supposed to rejuvenate the heart, mind and body of the consumer. Can *rasa* much subtler than even ash, also rejuvenate the soul? This was the occasion for Bharata Muni to develop a full fledged theory of *Rasa*.

Bharata Muni says that which can be relished – like the taste of food – is *rasa* - *Rasyate anena iti rasaha* (*asvadayatva*). Any art-performative like dance or drama or literature like poetry or *katha*, without *Rasa* is not complete. *Rasa* is the quality that mediates between the artists and the spectator.

Bharata formulated *Rasa* theory in the *Natyashastra* (5th century) under the famous Sutra *vibhavanubhavavyabhicharisamyogad rasanispattih*. That is the birth of *rasa* takes place when the *vibhava*, *anubhava* and the transitory mental states unite. *Rasa* is said to arise when the *sthayibhava* in the individual is awakened by his perception of the *vibhavas*, *anubhavas*, *vyabhicharibhava* and *sattvic bhavas*. What are these different components that evokes *Rasa* as whole? *Vibhavas* have been termed as the determiner by R. Gnoli. Gnoli explains the process how *vibhavas* as external stimuli like the story, stage and the actor, awakens our latent sentiment. *Anubhavas* are the consequents, deliberate manifestations of feelings on part of the actor in accordance with the mood. *Vyabhichari bhavas* are the transient moods that arise along with the basic permanent mood. For e.g. If the basic mood is love (*rati*), joy in union will be the accompanying emotion.

The *Natayashastra* mentions eight *Bhavas* and corresponding *Rasa*:

Bhava	Rasa
Rati (Love)	Sringara Rasa
Hasya (Mirth)	Hasya Rasa
Soka (Sorrow)	Karuna Rasa
Krodha(Anger)	Raudra Rasa
Utsaha (Energy)	Veera Rasa
Bhaya (Fear)	Bhayana Rasa
Jugupsa (Disgust)	Vibhava Rasa
Vismaya (Wonder)	Adbhuta Rasa

Rasa and bhava can be considered as Siamese twins: one without the other would not have a sensitive life. Rasa cannot be generated without bhava and vice-versa .

Following Bharata, the theory of Rasa was enunciated by Bhatta Lollata(9th century). Lollata examined it only in the context of performing arts like drama. For him, “Rasa is a sthayibhava intensified by a poetic description or the histrionics of the actors through Vibhavas, anubhavas etc.”(Sankaran, p.98) For Lollata, “Rasa primarily resides in the character and also in the actors on account of their imagining themselves for the moment to be those very same characters.”(Sankaran ,pp.98-99) For Lollata, it is the actor that exhibit the rasa and so it is they who realize it. There is no consideration for either the poet or the audience. But, how does the audience realize the Rasa?

Sri Sankuka criticized Lollata for equating rasa with Sthayibhava. Sankuka argued that when the spectator witness a perfect imitation/reproduction of the characters and their experiences , spectator forgets momentarily the difference between actor and the character and inferentially experiences the emotion of the character. This experience of emotion by spectator is a reflex of real emotional moods, sthayibhava of the characters. Inferential experience is the realization of Rasa. Sankuka brings in spectator in the realization of Rasa. But, how can it be said that either actor without knowing the original, imitate or the spectator without

knowing the original, infer the imitation? (Sankaran, p.99)

Then came Bhatta Nayak. He says Rasa is neither known through the means of knowledge , nor produced nor manifested. If it be a known thing, then in karuna, one must experience pain and not pleasure. If it is known through Sabda, there cannot be any sense of joy. The witnessing of actual love-making of two lovers on stage may cause aversion to the older spectators. Bhatta Nayak explores “hat really constitutes realization of Rasa”. (Sankaran ,p. 103). Sankaran argues that for Bhatta Nayak , the poetic language has three aspects-

1. *Abhidha* or significative

2. *Bhavana* or unificatory

3. *Bhojakatva* or Bhoga or realizationary.

All linguistic expression has abhidha. Only poetry has bhavana. The gunas and alankaras generate bhavana in ordinary poetry. “Difficulty in realization of Rasa is the individualistic element of the spectator of Saharidayas on one side and actors and characters on the other.”(Sankaran ,p.103) . Bhatta Nayak assumed the “unification of the character, sahridaya and the actor” . There is complete unification of three elements and this is called Sadharanikarana, a process which Abhinavagupta later made thorough use in his own theory. When there is a powerful representation, individual loses the individuality and aided by imaginative sympathy enters into sadharanikaran. When this emotion is universalized, the third aspect viz. Bhojakatva operates. Bhatta Nayak considers that Bhoga arises only through predominance of sattva guna over other two gunas and hence it is always pleasant. This resolves the problem as to how the karun rasa is also pleasant.

Abhinavagupta follows Bhatta Nayak but only differs in the terminology. For Abhinava, it is the dhvani or the suggestion which is the essence of the poetry. Abhinavagupta brings sadhranikarana or Bhavakatva of Bhatta Nayak under vyanjana and Bhoga under Rasapratiti.

Abhinavagupta now synthesized two different models- Anandavardana’s Theory of Dhvani fully developed in the four udyots(flash) of the Dhvanyaloka and Bhatta Nayak’s ideas on conception

of aesthetic experience enunciated in the Hridayadarpana.

In the Abhinavabharati, Abhinavagupta elaborated over the theory of Rasa in the sixth chapter. He discusses “whose rasa is it that we are realizing? Is it that of the poet or of the great characters or that of the actors or only of our own? Moreover, what are the different emotions that produce rasa? Most problematic for Abhinava was to explain how the painful emotions appeal to us? Though, we cry on tragic scenes and also shed tear, why do we feel inspired to return to read or watch same tragic scene once again and like to shed tears? Man wants to relish the pleasure but why is it that painful emotions expressed in literature charm us?” (Sankaran, p. 97)

Abhinavagupta's Poetics

Abhinavagupta's exposition of dhvani and rasa in his two works, Locana and the Abhinavabharati is remarkable feat of synthesizing different theories prevalent in poetics and dramaturgy. Abhinavagupta formulated the solution to the problems that Bhatta Nayak had to face by reposing his belief in immortal soul. All soul have in them implanted certain vasanas (instincts) which was known as the Sthayibhavas, more particularly in Sahridaya (responsive critics or emotional community). “When there is vivid representation of the Vibhavas (determinants), anubhavas (consequents) and vyabhicharibhavas (transitory mental states), this instinct is called forth and developed to that climax when it is realized by us, accompanied by thrill or joy.” (Sankaran, p. 104). This is the realization of Rasa. Rasa is the emotional mood revealed in blissful knowledge, free from barriers that hinders its realization. What are these sevenfold barriers? Gnoli discusses in his “The Aesthetic Experience According to Abhinavagupta” (1968):

1. **Unsuitability**- The lack of adequate realization of the probability of things. If one is not convinced of the things presented, one cannot be absorbed in full attention to realize Rasa. For extraordinary incident, the extraordinary characters are needed. To depict the plot of Hanuman crossing the sea, one has to present Hanuman as the extremely powerful son of the Wind.

2. **The immersion in temporal and spatial determinations** perceived as exclusively one's own or exclusively those of another- When the critic-

sahridaya sever himself from the object described and if he realizes happiness or sorrow as existing in himself, there may arise in him desire to preserve it or conceal it and so on, this hinders the realization of Rasa.

3. The fact of being at the mercy of our own sensation of pleasure- If one is overpowered by one's own happiness or sorrow, he cannot concentrate his attention on something else.

4. **The defective states of the means of perception-**

5. **The lack of evidence**

6. **The lack of some predominant factor**- Our mind does not rest satisfied with the knowledge of things subordinate, for it runs towards the predominant thing. Vibhavas, anubhavas, vyabhicharibhavas are subordinate and go to develop Sthayibhavas which are dominant. Sthayibhavas are regarded as dominant emotional state of being as these are directly associated with the dominant aimed of life, Purushartha. Rati is associated with kama, Dharma and artha. Sama (quietism) with the moksha. Vyabhicharibhavas are not of permanent nature and these are brought about by certain causes and when these are removed, the vyabhichari bhava disappears. Say, if one states, “This person is lazy.” One naturally is inclined to ask, “why is he so lazy?” That means laziness is not a permanent state but brought about by some temporary cause. But, if we take a statement, “Rama possess great energy and power”. No one is inclined to ask the question about his Utsaha. Utsaha is permanent.

7. **The presence of doubt**- Vibhavas, Anubhavas and Vyabhicharibhavas are not severally related to any specific Sthayibhava. Anubhava of Tear may arise out of joy or pain or sorrow or some disease in eye. When the death of a relative is the Vibhava, shedding tear is the anubhava and contemplation, weakness etc. the vyabhicharibhava, there may arise doubt regarding particular sthayibhava that is developed. When there is such specific combination, we know that sthayibhava developed is Shoka and the Rasa is karuna.

These seven barriers are overcome in the manner. Sahridaya through “imaginative sympathy identifies himself with the situation, and he realizes his own emotion that has been stirred and developed to a climax, free from all limitations and accompanied by thrill.” (Sankaran, p. 109). This realization is in the

nature of pure joy and alaukik, transcendental. It lasts only during the time of realization and never beyond it and is different from the Sthayibhava as it is not permanent state. This is the Rasa.

Abhinavagupta distinguishes between the world of drama/ representation and the real life. In art, one moves from the gross to more subtle forms of expressions and experiences. There is propensity to realize unity amidst multiplicity or what some Buddhist masters speculated, "to see a world in a grain of Sand". Abhinavagupta also grappled with the old problem as to how the feeling that might cause pain in real life is capable of providing pleasure in an art form. Here, he again borrowed Bhatta Nayak's idea that rasa is sattvic and hence always pleasant.

Abhinavagupta now had to synthesize ideas from the Samkhya philosophy to explain the dichotomy of enjoyable pathos. The emotional mood pertaining to karuna is Soka or grief. During realization of Karuna, mind gets so much absorbed in the representation (tanmayata) that it achieves a certain equipoise(sama). When mind attains the balance, free from any disturbance, delight is produced what Samkhya thinkers had propounded. This explains how tragic scenes are pleasurable, while human nature abhors the experience of pain. This also put a question mark over Buddhist worldview that there is dukha in the world. A connoisseur can generate bliss in this very life if he becomes a spectator of cosmic drama and evokes the Karuna rasa by transcending his limitations and individuality.

Abhinavagupta deals with each rasa corresponding with eight Sthayibhavas in his sixth chapter of Abhinavabharati. All these are related to three ends of life in Purushartha system- Dharma, artha, kama. That was another stupendous feat of creative fusion. Abhinavagupta now wanted to fit in the highest purushartha, moksha, under his aesthetic gaze. This he achieved by pitting for another Rasa, śānta rasa whose emotional mood is Sama(quietude), related to the moksha. Sama became sthayibhava for the śānta rasa.

The greatest achievement of Abhinavagupta in the field of aesthetic philosophy is his incorporation of śānta rasa in the theory of Rasa. Udbhata and Anandavardhana both had accepted Santa as the ninth

Rasa . But, it was Abhinavagupta who incorporated this Rasa in the emerging dominant paradigm. He perceived Santa as the ultimate in the process of rasa-realisation.

Abhinavagupta also described how Santa rasa underlies all the other eight rasas . Śānta rasa pervades all Rasas like the sixteenth digit of immortality of the Moon. The śānta Rasa is the ultimate rasa. All the other rasas emanate from the śānta rasa and resolve again into it. Bharat Muni says,

" All emotions, when their respective conditions or excitants obtain, proceed from Santa; and when the conditions are withdrawn they again merge or repose in santa." (Sankaran,p.116)

Since the realization of all rasa are alaukika and free from sensual enjoyment , it is necessarily of the nature of śānta rasa.

Abhinavagupta's novelty can be summarized as follow: Rasadhvani form the soul of poetry. In Bhatta Nayak's classifications of realization of rasa in place of Bhavakatva, suggestion or Vyanjana (dhvani) should be substituted . Even painful emotions is pleasant and the śānta rasa is the predominant Rasa among all the Rasas .

Abhinavagupta paved the literary path to moksha. The great literary works that has rasadhvani can finally lead to the experience of the śānta rasa. This had tremendous impact over India's literary tradition. The bhakti movement emerged that thrived with the wonderful poetic compositions and harnessing the aesthetic delight for mystical ecstasy. Post-Abhinavagupta, tremendous outpouring of poetic literature in the form of chalisa, manas, doha, chaupai, namvalli, sahastranam ensued across length and breath of India

Camatkāra as alaukik Rasa

The realization of Rasa is alaukika. It is different from ordinary experience which are produced by vibhava, anubhava and vyabhicharibhavas. In ordinary experience, even after the cause is destroyed , the effect continues to exist just like the chak(potter-wheel) which produces a pot, even if destroyed, the pot continues to exist. But, in Rasa, realization ends when the vibhavas etc. are withdrawn. There are other ordinary experience in which causes reveal things that

already exist. e.g. a lamp is the vibhava for revealing a pot that is kept in a dark room. But, in case of rasa, it is not correct to assume that rasa preexists the Vibhavas. Thus, rasa is not ordinary experience. Rasapratiti is *alaukika*. Rasa is neither *gyanpak* nor *karak*, it is carvanopayogi. It can be realized and savoured only. (Locana I. 18). Rasa is something which is produced sui generis after the process of chewing(*carvana*).

Rasa arises when senses get fully absorbed in something(*tanmaya*) to the exclusion of everything else. The objects which arouse this state may be food or *madya*(drink), a song or dance. Aesthetic and mystical state of consciousness have particular kind of bliss. This is Purnananda or the Supreme bliss. These are accompanied by sense of wonder, *camatkara*. *Camatkāra* is more than amazement. It emerges like lightening flash and fills with thrill. It is also *apurva* and *alaukik*. Abhinavagupta deploys the terminology first time in the Locana I.12 where he discusses that *vismaya* is not *camatkāra*. *Vismaya* is wonder. Sometimes *alaukik* words and their meanings generate curiosity(*kautuhul*) in us but these are not so intense as to fill us with the Rasa. Abhinavagupta takes up the example of *chitrakavya*. The structure, words and the meaning in *chitrakavya* may cause curiosity and wonder in us, but it is not the Principal *Kavya*. The true poetry has such a powerful flow that *sahridaya* get immersed in *rasa* and loses his individuality. Such is the *camatkarsar Rasa*. V. Raghvan mentions that the word “*camatkāra* was an onomatopoeic word referring to the clicking sound we make with our tongue when we taste something snappy, and in the course of its semantic enlargement, *camatkāra* came to mean a sudden fillip relating to any feeling of a pleasurable type.”(Raghvan: p. 269). But, the term “*camatkāra*” shares etymological affinity with “*chamak*”(brightness). *Camatkāra* involves act of sudden brightening, like the lightening flash, palpitating with enormous deindividuated joy. *Camatkar* is the nature of *Adi Siva* who two aspects-*Prakash*(illumination) and *vimarsha*(also known as *Anadashakti*, the mother of bliss). The highest spiritual realization mentioned by Sankaracharya in *Saundarya Lahiri* is that of *Shakti* in lightning-like *Kala* as *Sadakhya kala*(joyous lightening flash). (*Saundarya Lahiri*, verse. 21) Similarly, the *Kundalini Shakti* is described as resting in the ground within

body that rises like lightening and showers the aspirant with inexpressible, *alaukika* bliss. *Camatkāra* as a concept is a paradigmatic invention to narrate the ultimate experiential encounter of an individual. In *Saundarya Lahiri*, *Samkaracharya* mentions the.

Utpaldeva, master of *Abhinavagupta* is the first to use the term in technical sense. *Bhatta Nayak* used the same in his *Hridayadarpana*. *Camatkāra* is synonymous with the Buddhist *Samvega* and *Vismaya* of the *Spanda* school. Here, the term is used in the sense that the ordinary *laukika* world is suddenly replaced by a novelty, an ‘*apurva*’ incidence.. *Abhinavagupta* “states that *camatkāra* is present in every form of life. It is the what distinguishes the conscious beings with inanimate matter. Aesthetic sensibility is nothing but capacity of wonder, more condensed than ordinary wonder. Probably, this is the challenge for scientists working with machine consciousness. What after robots pass Turing Test? Can machine consciousness experience *camatkāra*?

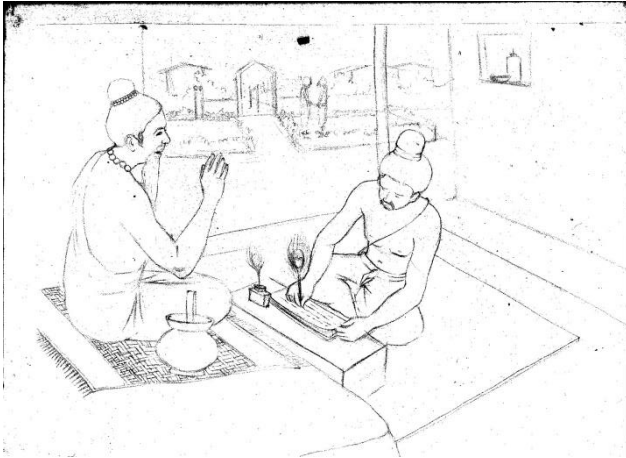
For *Abhinavagupta* *camatkāra* provided a convenient solution for the unpleasurable *rasa* problem, since the spectator was now expected to feel a detached cognitive delight, regardless of the emotional value of the text. *Rasa* for *Abhinavagupta* involved a deindividuated affective state (*sadharanibhava*) occurring in the spectator’s mind and extracted from a remembered personal experience of emotion. The immersion in delight(*bhogāveśa*) is *camatkāra*. It is a state of *rasavesha*-rush of *rasa*. The *rasa* gush forth and pours the being just as spark catches fire in dry wood. Even if a play is based upon the *bibhatsa* or *karuna* *rasas*, the resulting feeling in the reader or spectator is *camatkāra*, which fills the individual with delight. This is the reason the TV serials depicting fear as the predominant theme like *Fear Files*, continue to enthrall the spectators and attract the viewer to repeatedly watch the ever new episodes. In real life, everyone wish never ever to encounter such situation, but as spectator derive the maximum joy out of the same situation.

The aesthetic experience is a direct experience sui generic, free of every *vibhava* or *anubhava*, determinant and consequents. This form of consciousness without obstacles has been termed *camatkāra*. *Abhinavagupta* has discussed the physical effect of *camatkāra* like trembling, horripilation, *ullkasana*-joyful motion of limbs. Moreover the aesthetic experience of *camatkāra* appears each time

the poetic expressions that aroused it, are evoked. Camatkara is svatantra(free) from the impediments. It is absolutely independent state of joy. In Tantraloka, Abhinavagupta always invokes the imagery of *camatkâra* to describe the esoteric energy lying dormant within our body. The divine resides within the human body(Deva-sadan-deha) and the lowest chakra, muladhar is soaked with camatkrit rasa that emanates the nectar of joy.(Tantraloka: Chapter 29.176; Chapter 26.63). Rasa is the essence of cognitive chewing- carvana. It is immediate and not something that pre-exists before the cognition. Rasa is different from natural eight permanent mental states(sthayibhava). Rasa is *alaukik*. Rasa is the *camatkâra*.

Cont.

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His forthcoming work is on *Nalanda Tradition*)**



A glimpse in Abhinavagupta's ideas on aesthetics

Geetika Kaw Kher

Abhinavagupta a distinguished philosopher, aesthete and saint was one of the most outstanding Acharyas of the Monistic Shaivism. His exact date of birth is not known but we learn from references about him in his works *Tantraloka* and *Paratrimshika Vivarana* that he lived in Kashmir about the end of the tenth and beginning of the eleventh century A.D. The earliest known ancestor of Abhinavagupta was a famous Brahmin *Attrigupta* a great Shaiva teacher and scholar of *Kanauj*, who had been invited to settle in Kashmir by King *Lalitaditya*. Abhinava Gupta was thus born in a family which had a long tradition of scholarship and devoutness for Lord Siva. His father *Narasimhagupta* (*Cukhulaka*) and mother *Vimalakala* were great influence in his life and it is believed that they both underwent austerities to be bestowed with an extra ordinary son with spiritual powers.

Traditionally believed to have been a *Yoginibhu* (born of a *Yogini*), he mastered subjects like metaphysics, poetry and aesthetics at a very young age. He possessed all the eight Yogic powers explained in *Shastras*. His biographers observed six great spiritual signs as explained in '*Malinivijayotara Shastra*', in him. Kashmir Shaivism is classified by Abhinavagupta in four systems viz. *Krama* system, *Spanda* system, *Kula* system and *Pratyabijnnya* system. '*Krama*' deals with space and time, '*Spanda*', with the movement, '*Kula*' with the Science of Totality and '*Pratyabijnnya*' with the school of Recognition. (Ref G.T.Deshpande's monogram on Abhinava Gupta for detailed explanation)

His two major works on Poetics, *Dhavyalokalocana* and *Abhinava Bharati* point towards his quest into the nature of aesthetic experience. In both these works Abhinava Gupta suggests that Aesthetic experience is something beyond worldly experience and he has used the word '*Alaukika*' to distinguish the former feeling from the mundane latter ones. He subscribed to the theory of *Rasa Dhvani* and thus entered the ongoing aesthetic debate on nature of Aesthetic pleasure. *Rasa*--roughly translated: "as emotive aesthetics"--is one of the most important concept in classical Indian aesthetics, having pervasive influence in theories of painting, sculpture, dance, poetry, and drama. . *Rasa* theory argues that the presentation of emotions is the

proper object and domain of poetic discourse. Bharata in *Natyashastra* his pioneering work on Indian dramatics mentions eight *rasas* and says *Rasa* is produced when '*Vibhaava*', *Anubhava* and *Vyabhichari bhava* come together. *Vibhavanubhava-vyabhicari-samyogat Rasa nispattih* (*Rasa Sutra, Natyasastra*)

Vibhava: A medium through which an emotion arises in an actor e.g. A child riding a stick and enjoying it as if he were actually riding a horse
Anubhava: All the physical changes arising due to the *vibhavas* e.g. changes in facial expression and body language

Vyabichari bhava: Transient emotions eg. weeping with joy

The language of feelings is not a private language; it is more a system of symbols, a language game that is understood by those who have learned its conventions and usages. Emotions treated in a poem are neither the projections of the reader's own mental states nor the private feelings of the poet; rather, they are the objective situations abiding in the poem as its cognitive content. *Rasa* is understood as residing in the situational factors presented in an appropriate language. A poet chooses a theme because he sees a certain promise for developing its emotional possibilities and exploits it by dramatizing its details. The adherents of *rasa* theory believed *rasa*, to be the meaning of the poetic sentence but they had different ideas about the definition of art. Abhinavabharati a commentary on Bharata's *Natyasastra* talks about these scholars and comments on their theories. Bhatta *Lollata* believed art to be an imitation of reality. His views were contested by *Sri Sankuka* who stated that art cannot be an imitation simply because it exists in a different place and time. Further he explained his point of view by giving the analogy of a pictorial horse (*chitaraturaganyaya*). He says when one sees a horse painted one doesn't mistake it for the original horse but one sees it as the representation of the original horse and thus derives the aesthetic pleasure through this identification. Since art cannot imitate all the qualities of the original subject hence it is just an inference and not an imitation. Bhatta *Tauta*, Abhinavagupta's teacher raised a valid question regarding the imitation of the mental state. According to him there is no way an actor can feel and react in exactly the same way as the original character. The actor presents his feelings i.e. How he would react if put in the original characters position. Hence art cannot be inferred but depends on the imagination of

the spectator. Abhinavagupta though agrees to many of the suggestions put forward by Rasa theory also points at its various limitations. According to him art is not just about evoking certain feelings but a real work of art in addition to possessing emotive charge needs to have a strong sense of suggestion and capacity to produce various meanings. This is where he refers to Dhvanivada . He says that for a work of art it is not enough to be having abhida(literal meaning) and laksana(metaphorical meaning) but it should also possess Vyanjana the suggested meaning which has absolutely nothing to do with the other two levels of meaning. Thus an aesthetic experience cannot be experienced like any ordinary mundane experience. A true aesthetic object does not simply stimulate the senses but also stimulates the imagination of the spectator. Once the imagination is stimulated the spectator aesthete gets transported to a world of his own creation. This emotion deindividualises an individual by freeing him from those elements which constitute individuality such as place, time etc. and raises him to the level of universal. Thus art is otherworldly or Alaukika in its nature.

One of the major passage in which he dwells on alaukikatva is:

“When a man hears the words :’A son is born to you’ joy is produced (through the power of denotation-abhida).But the suggested sense (rasa and the like) is not produced the way joy is produced in the above case. Nor does it come about through the secondary usage (laksana,gunavrtti,bhakti).But it arises in a sensitive man (sahridaya-a man who is sensitive to literature)through his knowledge of vibhavas and anubhava, because of his hrdaya-samvada (sympathetic response)and his tanmayibhava (identification). It is vilaksana (different)from ordinary awareness of happiness etc. and it is not an objective thing” Dhvaynalokalocana, p.79

In this passage he points out clearly that the vibhavas do not correspond to any karana(reason) in case of art like they do in everyday life. They make the relish of Rasa possible and hence exist at a different plane altogether.

Abhinavagupta turned his attention away from the linguistic and related abstractions which had preoccupied even Anandavardhana, focusing his

attention instead on the human mind, specifically the mind of the reader or viewer of a literary work. The first step in Abhinavagupta's project involved the recognition that the theory of rasadhvani , could not be understood as a theory of abstract linguistic structure. Rather, it only made sense as a theory of the way people respond to literature. In other words, rasadhvani had to be conceived in psychological terms. According to this system the reader becomes the central focus of literary criticism. The aim of kavya is to give pleasure, but this pleasure must not bind the soul to the body. Thus he attributed the state of divinity to arts and considered Shanta Rasa as the ultimate Rasa. According to him the pleasure one derives out of a real work of art is no less than divine pleasure. As one has to constantly struggle and detach oneself to reach the Almighty similarly a true connoisseur of arts has to learn to detach the work from its surroundings and happenings and view it independently e.g. the feeling that might bring pain in real life is capable of causing pleasure in an art form. The great success of Greek tragedies can be attributed to the pleasure it aroused in the spectators and brought about the emotional Catharsis (purging out)

In his Dhvanyaloka Anandavardhana observes: “In the province of poetry (creative literature) obviously standards of truth and falsity have no relevance. Any attempt to find out or discover whether a poem (or any literary composition) is true or false by employing means of valid cognition leads to ridicule alone” Abhinavagupta comments on it :”Such a person will be ridiculed as follows: He is not able or competent to appreciate aesthetic experience or his mind has become (truly) hard by indulging in dry logic.” Thus he asserts that the “willful suspension of disbelief” is a prerequisite for enjoying any art form. The moment one starts questioning it or doubting it and looking at it objectively it loses its charm and status and becomes equivalent to any mundane object. One enjoys a play only when one can identify the character as the character from the drama and not as ones friend or associate. For the time that the drama goes on the character should take over the actor in a spectators mind i.e. The spectator should rise above the worldly connections and try to experience the supernatural aspect of art which has nothing to do with the worldly concerns.



YTA Presence in various seminars and conferences on Acarya Abhinavagupta

Rashneek Kher

The year gone by was marked as the year of millennium celebration of *Acharya Abhinavguptpada*. A series of seminars across institutions of research & learning in various cities observed, discussed and talked about this great genius of Kashmir. It was in this context that Lal Bahadur Shastri Rashtriya Sanskrit Vidhyapeetha organized a three day seminar from 25th to 28th Nov, 2016 to discuss the contribution of *Acharya Abhinavguptpada* to Indian thought and philosophy. Our Guru Maharaj **Dandi Swami Paranand Teerthji** delivered the keynote speech at the inaugural day of the seminar.

There couldn't have been a more opportune institution in the present day where one could talk about *Abhinavguptpada*. The Vidhyapeetha presents a picture of what our old schools of lore would have been like. You hear rumblings in Sanskrit, students prostrating themselves before their teachers not to mention the curriculum which essentially draws itself from the various thoughts of Indian Philosophy.

Upon our arrival at the Campus, Guru Maharaj was given a ceremonial welcome. As he ascended on the stage one could see a galaxy of scholars from Prof Navjivan Rastogi to Dr. Radha Vallabh Tripathi and many others sitting in the front row. It was truly awe inspiring and spiritually uplifting to be in the same hall as that of such great scholars whose thoughts and

works we have grown up reading.



Swamiji started with slokas which I could not understand literally but the import of which wasn't lost on anyone else in the seminar hall because here I was like a dunce sitting amongst students and teachers who were used to conversing in Sanskrit. In a succinct fashion Swamiji spoke about the life and times of *Abhinavagupta*. He mentioned the names of his various teachers and his illustrious lineage. It was here that Swamiji mentioned of the connect rather the continuity of thought between the Indian mainland and Kashmir and how Kashmir Saivadarshan wasn't an island of a thought but one that was intimately connected to the large and arcane body of work which great seers of different schools from Advaita to Shakta to Tantra had mastered and carried forward. It is here that Swamiji spoke about the great master *Somananda* and his *Siva Drishti* and all other masters whose lineage and thought percolated down to *Abhinavagpt*. Special mention was however mentioned of *Shambunatha*, the most prominent teacher of *Abhinavagupt*.



Swamiji spoke briefly about *Abhinavagpt's* contribution to various disciplines of Indian thought and the works of *Abhinavagupt* on aesthetics,

philosophy, logic, theology etc. Brief references were made about *Tantralok*, *IshvaraPratibhijyanaVimarsini* and its *vritti* and *Abhinavbharti*. References were made to later scholars and disciples like Kshemraja and Jayaratha who carried forward the work of the great master.

The successful beginning of the Millenium celebrations of Acharya Abhinavagupta by IGNCA was marked by the first national seminar organised in J&K in collaboration with the Dept. of Philosophy and Culture, Shri Mata Vaishno Devi University, Katra (J&K) on 4th-5th September, 2016. The second national seminar in the series was organised in collaboration with Bharat Bhavan at Bhopal from 4th to 6th November 2016. The three days main event of the international seminar along with an exhibition and performances dedicated to Acarya Abhinavagupta was organised in the premises of IGNCA from 15th to 17th December 2016.

Geetika Kaw Kher of YTA presented her paper on 'Contribution of Abhinavagupta to the development of Pratyabhijñā philosophy' during the three day International seminar and exhibition on Acarya Abhinavagupta, at IGNCA on 17th Dec 2016.



Her paper focused on some salient features of Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vimarśini, Abhinavagupta's commentary on Utpalācārya's Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Kārikā and explored the concept of cognitive power as explained and discussed by Abhinavagupta.

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